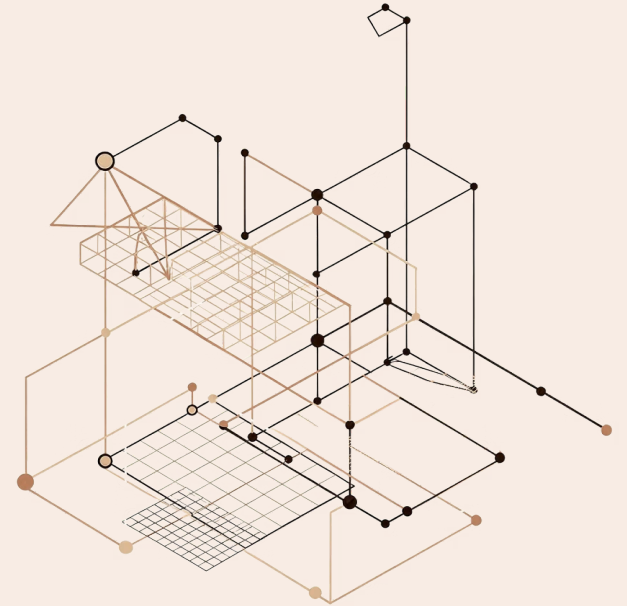


Systems, Structures, and the Illusion of Neutrality

A semester-long investigation into how systems encode values, construct legibility, and present themselves as neutral.

Candace Stewart



I Used to Think Technology Was Neutral.

Not because I thought it was perfect – but because I believed it was *trying to help*. Data and systems felt like tools for making better decisions, solving problems faster, and making things fairer.

Then I started noticing patterns.

→ Facial Recognition

Failing to recognize darker skin tones.

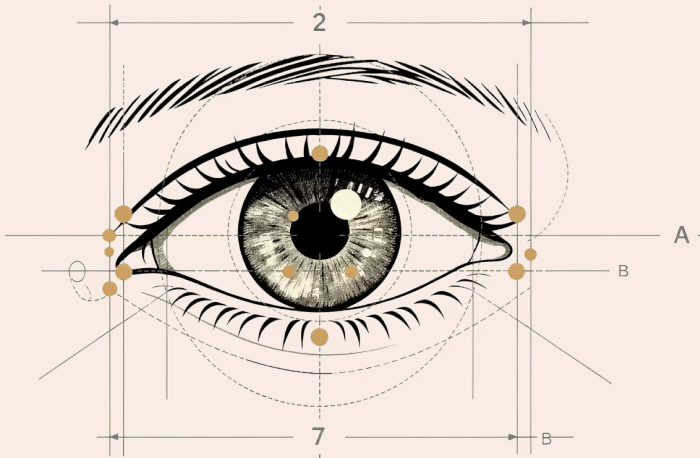
→ Recommendation Systems

Shaping what people see, believe, and become.

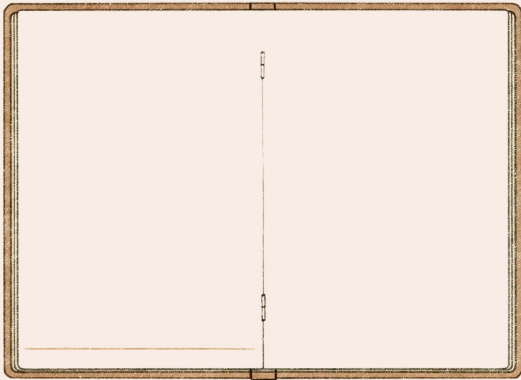
→ Institutional Forms

Reducing human complexity into predefined categories.

How do systems quietly shape human behavior while presenting themselves as neutral?



Research Foundation



At the start of the semester, I turned to **feminist systems thinking** – not as a finished theory, but as a framework for asking different kinds of questions.

I studied thinkers examining care, maintenance, invisible labor, infrastructure, and the hidden assumptions embedded in systems. This research helped me see systems not as purely technical – but as structures that carry social values.

| Systems are never neutral. They encode values.

Donna Haraway

Susan Leigh Star

**María Puig de la
Bellacasa**

Shannon Mattern



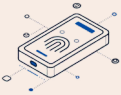
PROJECT ONE

Who Is This Built For?

The first major phase explored how systems construct and interpret people through datasets, categorization, and institutional legibility. What began as an investigation into *lived experience* – confusion, fatigue, invisibility – deepened into structural questions about classification, measurement, and the conditions under which certain people become recognizable to systems at all.

Who Was This Built For?

Each entry examined a different way systems translate human experience into structured, measurable data.



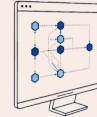
The Body as Dataset

Biometric scans, health metrics, and facial recognition turn bodies into structured information – but not every body equally.



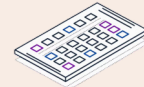
The Mind as Dataset

Mood tracking, learning platforms, and behavioral analytics attempt to organize subjective experience into categories that can be managed.



Behavior as Dataset

Platforms construct behavioral identities from interaction – but behavior inside a system is always shaped by the structure of the system itself.



Identity as Dataset

Forms, dropdowns, and risk scores translate identity into classification – and the score becomes infrastructure for access and institutional trust.

Systems do not simply observe people. They construct the conditions under which people become understandable.

What Project One Revealed

Project One helped me understand how systems shape people through **categorization, standardization, and institutional legibility**.

It revealed that emotional responses – confusion, fatigue, invisibility, self-blame – could be understood not as personal failures, but as **outputs of structural friction**.

But eventually I realized this still did not fully answer my larger question. Project One explained *what* systems do to people. It did not fully explain *where those systems came from*.

**What systems
do to people**

Answered ✓

**Where systems
come from**

The next question →

How do systems become inherited? How do structures lose visible authorship over time?

Tracing Lineage

The project moved from *experience* to *lineage*. I was no longer only asking who this was built for – I started asking where the structure came from, who designed it, who copied it, and when it became standard.

1 Who designed it?

Original authorship, often invisible or forgotten.

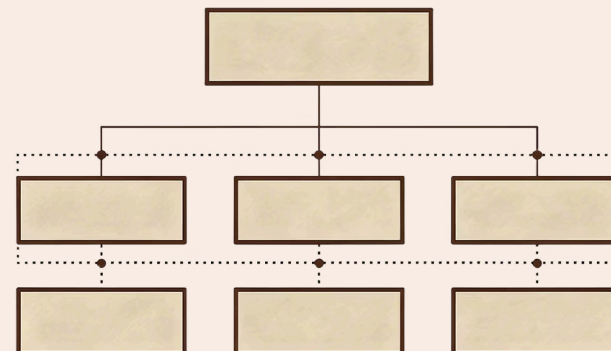
2 Who copied it?

Inheritance without attribution or critique.

3 When did it become standard?

The moment nobody felt responsible for it anymore.

Many systems feel natural because they are inherited.



Expanding the Archive

As the project evolved, the research expanded beyond feminist systems thinking into larger questions about **infrastructure, archives, normalization, and anonymous history**.

These thinkers helped me understand how systems become inherited – and how power shapes what becomes visible, remembered, or erased.

Stewart Brand

Systems as networks of relationships, not isolated objects.

Mindy Seu

Interfaces and archives shape visibility, participation, and memory.

Siegfried Giedion

Ordinary infrastructures shape daily life until they stop appearing designed.

Michel-Rolph Trouillot

Power shapes what becomes normalized, remembered, or erased.

Unknown Origin

The second major artifact cataloged the **recurring structural forms** underneath systems – forms so common they begin to feel inevitable rather than designed.



The Limit

Structural constraints shaping expression before it begins.



The Field

Information organized before participation is possible.



The Default

Preconfigured behavior presented as neutral or universal.



The Dropdown

Categories shaping identity through constrained selection.

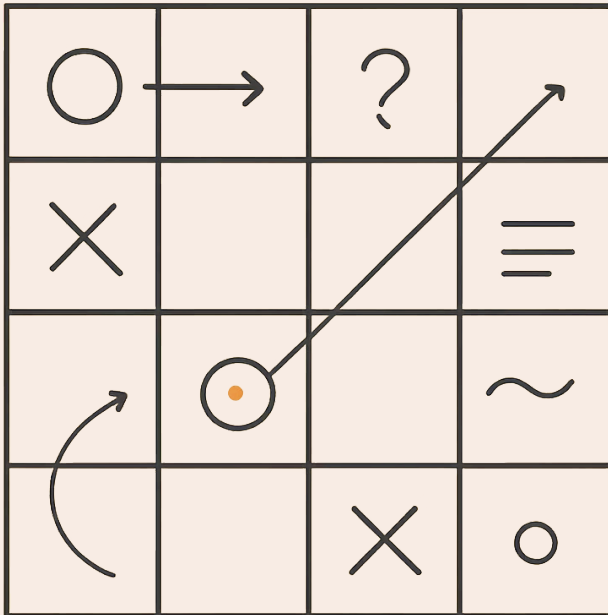


The Timestamp

Experience transformed into measurable, linear sequence.

Commonness does not equal neutrality.

Why Field Guides and Zines?



I did not want this project to exist only inside academic language. I wanted to create something that could be *handed to someone*, flipped through, and understood through observation rather than specialized theory.

Field Guides

Tools for noticing structures in everyday systems.

Catalogs

Inventories of recurring, anonymous forms.

Zines

Accessible, portable, reproducible critique.

The format became part of the research. The project became less about producing answers and more about **building tools for noticing**.

Reflection

This project did not end with a final answer. It became an ongoing research question – one that evolved rather than resolved.

Feminist Systems Thinking

Care-focused frameworks that reshaped how I asked questions

Inherited Structures

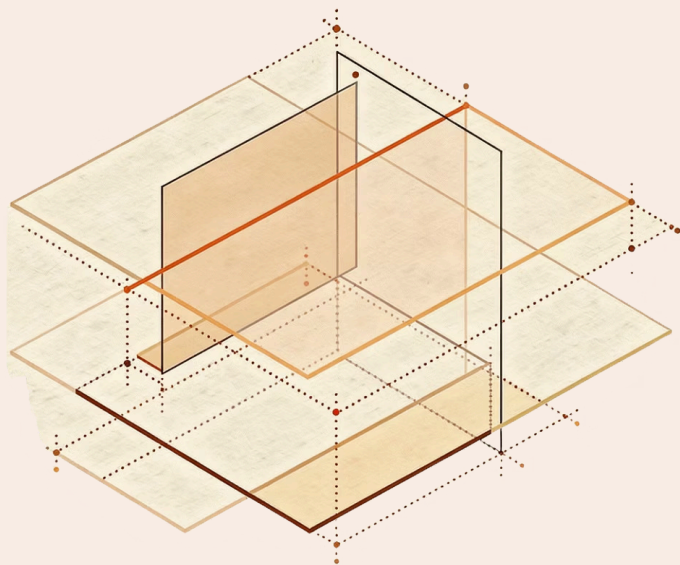
Anonymous history, normalized infrastructure, invisible authorship

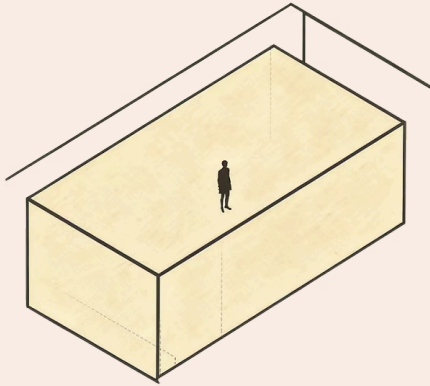
Lived Experience as Data

Classification, legibility, and the friction of being read by systems

Changing direction was not failure.

The evolution was the learning.





Noticing is a form of research.

Naming is a form of critique. Visibility creates the possibility for redesign.

Many systems feel **neutral**
because they are familiar.

Many systems feel **natural**
because they are inherited.

But once we can **name structures**, we can begin to question them.